

THE INDIAN RENAISSANCE

The Indian Renaissance was a 19th-century movement that reshaped India's cultural, social, and intellectual landscape, laying the foundation for independence.

- **Factors Driving Socio-Religious Reform Movements:** Colonial rule introduced **Western education**, promoting **liberty, equality, and democracy**, while **Christian missionaries** advanced **cultural exchange**. Social issues like **sati, child marriage, polygamy, and caste discrimination** spurred reforms, with **British rationalism** exposing India's stagnation. Scholars rediscovered India's ancient heritage, fostering **national pride** and reform. Rising **nationalism** called for **social reforms** to modernise and unify the nation. **Women's oppression**, highlighted by **sati and child marriage**, became a central issue, with reformers like **Raja Rammohan Roy** advocating for **women's rights**.
- **Ideological Foundations:**
 - **Rationalism:** Reformers like **Rammohan Roy** promoted reason, advocating **widow remarriage** and opposing **child marriage and polygamy**.
 - **Religious Universalism:** Leaders like **Roy, Syed Ahmed Khan, and Keshub Chandra Sen** emphasised **unity, equality**, and criticised **caste discrimination**.
 - **Humanism:** Focused on **human welfare** and moral values, seeing **religion** as a tool for societal progress.

Two Strands of Reform Movements

1. **Reformist Movements:** **Brahmo Samaj, Prarthana Samaj, and Aligarh Movement**. Focused on **religious reform** and emphasised **reason and conscience** over tradition.
2. **Revivalist Movements:** **Arya Samaj, Ramakrishna Mission, and Deoband Movement**. Aimed to **restore religious purity** and drew heavily on **traditional practices**.

WOMEN'S ISSUES AND REFORMS

Abolition of Sati

- **Raja Rammohan Roy and William Bentinck** played critical roles in abolishing **Sati**. Due to Roy's efforts, **Regulation XVII of 1829** under the Bengal Code declared Sati illegal, viewing it as **"murder according to every shastra."**
- **Historical Efforts:** Earlier restrictions were seen under the **Portuguese, Dutch, and French** in the 16th century. **Akbar**, the Mughal emperor, issued orders against coerced Sati in 1582.

Ban on Infanticide

- **Infanticide**, a grave practice especially among **Bengalis and Rajputs**, was driven by economic concerns and societal pressures.
- **Bengal Regulations of 1795 (Regulation XXI) and 1804 (Act III)** classified infanticide as murder to discourage this practice.
- **Birth Registration Act, 1870:** Required parents to record every birth and verify female children to reduce infanticide, particularly in regions where it was practiced covertly.

Legalisation of Widow Remarriage

- **Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar**, as the Principal of Sanskrit College, researched ancient texts and demonstrated widow remarriage was permitted by **Vedic scriptures**. With 987 signatories, he petitioned the government, leading to the **Hindu Widow's Remarriage Act, 1856 (Act XV of 1856)**, which legalised widow remarriage and recognized children from these unions as legitimate, although its impact was limited in Bengal.
- In Western India, **D.K. Karve** championed widow remarriage, married a widow himself in 1893, and became the **Widow Remarriage Association's secretary**. He established a **Widows' Home in Pune (1896)** for vocational training and in 1916, founded the **Indian Women's University** in Bombay.

- Reformers **Veeresalingam Pantulu** (Madras), **Jagannath Shankar Seth**, **Bhau Daji**, **Vishnu Shastri Pandit**, **Karsondas Mulji**, **B.M. Malabari**, **Narmad Dave**, **Justice Govind Mahadeo Ranade**, **K. Natarajan**, **Jyotiba Phule**, and **Savitribai Phule** promoted widow remarriage and women's rights across India.

Ban on Child Marriage

- **Native Marriage Act (Civil Marriage Act), 1872:** Prohibited marriage for girls below 18 and boys below 21. However, it did not apply to **Hindus, Muslims**, or other recognized faiths, limiting its reach.
- **B.M. Malabari**, a Parsi reformer, led efforts to end child marriage, which, along with **Rukhmabai's** landmark case, led to the **Age of Consent Act, 1891**—raising the minimum marriage age for girls to 12.
 - **Rukhmabai Raut**, India's first female physician and child marriage reformer, married at 11 to Dadaji Bhikaji, contested her marriage's validity. After her appeal was lost in 1887, public outcry led Queen Victoria to intervene, avoiding her imprisonment. The **Rukhmabai Defence Committee**, with **Behramji Malabari** and **Ramabai Ranade**, highlighted her case, inspiring the **Age of Consent Act, 1891**.
- **Sharda Act/Child Marriage Restraint Act, 1929:** Increased the marriage age to 18 for boys and 14 for girls; effective in 1930.
- **Child Marriage Restraint (Amendment) Act, 1978:** Raised marriage age to 18 for girls and 21 for boys in independent India.

Women's Education

19th-Century Misconceptions: Female education faced resistance due to beliefs that it was contrary to Hindu scriptures and would lead to widowhood, which reformers actively sought to dispel.

- **Early Initiatives:**
 - **Calcutta Female Juvenile Society (1819):** Established by Christian missionaries as one of the first organisations for girls' education in India.
 - **Bethune School (1849):** Founded by **J.E.D. Bethune** in Calcutta, marking a milestone in women's education and encouraging similar efforts across the region.
 - **Charles Wood's Despatch (1854):** Supported by Lord Dalhousie, this despatch highlighted the need for educating women as part of broader educational reforms.
- **Prominent Advocates:**
 - **Jagannath Shankarsheth:** A founder of the **School Society and Native School of Bombay**; he promoted girls' education and opened an English-Marathi school in Girgaum, Maharashtra.

- **Bhau Daji Lad:** First Indian president of the **Students' Literary and Scientific Society** and an active promoter of girls' schools in Maharashtra.
- **Jyotirao Phule and Savitribai Phule:** Opened the **first girls' school in Bhide Wada, Pune (1848)**. Savitribai Phule taught alongside **Fatima Sheikh** and **Sagunabai** and even established a **night school**.
- **Cornelia Sorabji:** The first woman to graduate from Bombay University (1887), she advocated for women's access to higher education.
- **Pt. Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar:** Instrumental in establishing girls' schools across Bengal and challenging misconceptions that female education was against Hindu scriptures.
- **Notable Institutions:**
 - **Alexandra Society (1863):** Formed by Parsis to educate Parsi girls.
 - **Women's Medical Service (1914):** Focused on training nurses and midwives, playing a vital role in women's healthcare education.
 - **Indian Women's University (1916):** Founded by **Professor D.K. Karve** to provide higher education for women.
 - **Lady Hardinge Medical College (1916):** Opened in Delhi to train women in medical sciences.

Women's Organisations

- **Arya Mahila Samaj (1882):** Founded by **Pandita Ramabai Saraswati** to advocate for women's rights and education. Her efforts led to the inclusion of medical education for women at **Lady Dufferin College**.
- **Ladies Social Conference (Bharat Mahila Parishad) (1904):** Established by **Ramabai Ranade** in Bombay under the **National Social Conference**, focusing on social reforms for women.
- **Bharat Stree Mahamandal (1910):** **Sarla Devi Chaudhurani** convened the first meeting in Allahabad, marking it as the first major women-led organisation in India. It aimed to improve women's education, abolish the purdah system, and elevate women's socio-economic and political status. Sarla Devi likened the struggle to live "under the shade of Manu."
- **National Council of Women in India (1925):** Formed with significant contributions from **Meherbai Tata**, along with **Cornelia Sorabji**, **Tarabai Premchand**, **Shaffi Tyabji**, and **Maharani Sucharu Devi**. The council addressed issues such as the purdah system, caste restrictions, and women's lack of education. Although some critics viewed their approach as elitist, they made vital contributions to social reform.

- **All India Women's Conference (AIWC) (1927):** Founded by **Margaret Cousins**, with the first meeting at Fergusson College, Pune. Founding members included **Maharani Chimnabai Gaekwad**, **Rani Sahiba of Sangli**, **Sarojini Naidu**, **Kamla Devi Chattopadhyaya**, and **Lady Dorab Tata**. AIWC promoted social justice, equal rights, and equitable distribution of resources, regardless of gender or birth.

Key Legislations for Women's Rights and Empowerment

- **Sarda Act (1929)**, **Hindu Women's Right to Property Act (1937)**, **Factory Act (1947)**, **Hindu Marriage and Divorce Act (1954)**, **Special Marriage Act (1954)**, **Hindu Minority and Guardianship Act (1956)**, **Hindu Adoption and Maintenance Act (1956)**, **Suppression of Immoral Traffic in Women Act (1958)**, **Maternity Benefits Act (1961)**, **Dowry Prohibition Act (1961)**, **Equal Remuneration Act (1976)**.

Women Movements and Personalities

Movement/Event	Key Women Personalities	Contributions/Significance
1872 - Early Feminist Movement	Dr. Rakhmabai	Dr. Rakhmabai's legal battle against child marriage led to the Age of Consent Act in 1891, and she became one of the first female doctors in colonial India.
1872 - Kuka Movement	Women of the Kuka Community	Women in the Kuka community in Punjab actively participated in protests against British rule, providing significant support for the movement.
1905 - Partition of Bengal	Swarnakumari Devi, Sarala Devi Chaudhurani	Swarnakumari Devi and Sarala Devi Chaudhurani were key figures in the protests against the Partition of Bengal and played an important role in the Swadeshi movement.
1916 - Home Rule Movement	Annie Besant, Margaret Cousins	Annie Besant led the Home Rule League, while Margaret Cousins co-founded the Women's Indian Association, advocating for women's suffrage across regions like Madras, Maharashtra, Gujarat, and U.P.
1917 - Women's Indian Association	Annie Besant, Dorothy Jinarajadasa, Margaret Cousins	The Women's Indian Association, founded by these women, worked towards women's suffrage and social reforms, beginning in Madras.
1919 - Rowlatt Satyagraha	Kasturba Gandhi, Sarojini Naidu	Kasturba Gandhi and Sarojini Naidu were instrumental in protesting the Rowlatt Act and participating in the Satyagraha against repressive British laws.
1921 - Non-Cooperation Movement	Basanti Debi, Suniti Devi	Basanti Debi was the first woman to be arrested for the movement, and Suniti Devi promoted the spinning of khadi and the boycott of foreign goods in Bengal.
1925 - Trade Union Movements	Anasuya Sarabhai	Anasuya Sarabhai founded the Ahmedabad Textile Labour Association, advocating for labour rights and better working conditions for textile workers.
1927 - All India Women's Conference (AIWC)	Margaret Cousins	Margaret Cousins was a central figure in founding the AIWC, which promoted women's education, social rights, and economic empowerment.
1929 - Child Marriage Restraint Act (Sarda Act)	Muthulakshmi Reddi	Muthulakshmi Reddi, the first woman legislator in Chennai's Legislative Council, played a crucial role in advocating for the Child Marriage Restraint Act.
1930 - Salt Satyagraha	Sarojini Naidu, Mithuben Petit	Sarojini Naidu led the Dharasana Salt Works raid, and Mithuben Petit was also a prominent participant in the Salt Marches.
1930s - Revolutionary Movement	Santi Ghose, Suniti Chaudhuri	Santi Ghose and Suniti Chaudhuri were involved in the assassination of a British district magistrate, marking the entry of women into revolutionary activities.

1930s - Civil Disobedience Movement	Usha Mehta, Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay	Usha Mehta ran the secret Congress Radio, and Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay was arrested for promoting self-reliance through handicrafts and selling contraband salt.
1942 - Quit India Movement	Aruna Asaf Ali, Sucheta Kriplani, Matangini Hazra, Kasturba Gandhi, Parbati Giri, Bina Das	Aruna Asaf Ali hoisted the Indian flag at Gowalia Tank, while Sucheta Kriplani organised protests. Matangini Hazra became a martyr, and Kasturba Gandhi participated in multiple protests. Parbati Giri provided humanitarian services, and Bina Das attempted to assassinate the Governor of Bengal.
1943 - Bengal Famine	Kalyani Das, Bina Das	Kalyani Das and Bina Das played vital roles in famine relief efforts and contributed to the fight for India's independence.
1947 - Partition of India	Rameshwari Nehru, Mridula Sarabhai	Rameshwari Nehru and Mridula Sarabhai focused on refugee rehabilitation and women's welfare in the aftermath of Partition.

CASTE ISSUES AND REFORMS

Caste as an Oppressive Force

- **Chatur Varnashrama** created rigid caste hierarchies, dictating **social status**, **education**, **land ownership**, **marriage**, and access to **profession**.
- **Untouchability** harms **human dignity**, restricting **social mobility**.
- **Lower castes** followed religious reformers, while **upper-caste Hindus** led **19th-century socio-religious reforms**, with limited success.

Colonial India and Social Awakening

- British rule spurred **social and political awakening**, particularly among **marginalised communities**.
- **Lower caste movements** sought **social justice** and equality.

Caste System and Colonialism

- The caste system caused **discrimination** and **poverty**, intensified by **colonial oppression**.
- **Lower castes** faced a **double burden** under both caste and British rule.

Factors Driving Caste Movements

- **Divide and rule** policies heightened **caste awareness**.
- **Western education** and **legal reforms** (Indian Penal Code, 1861; Criminal Procedure Code, 1872) promoted **equality**.
- **Railway expansion** and **national unity** challenged caste hierarchies, fueling movements for **equality** and **social change**.

Lower Caste Movements in Colonial India

Movement	Key Contributions and Facts
Satyashodhak Samaj (Truth Seekers' Society) [1873] Maharashtra (UPSC 2016)	• Founder: Jyotirao Phule • Objective: Social justice, education for lower castes and women • Leadership: Malis, Telis, Kunbis • Critique of Caste: Brahmanical Tyranny: Exploitation through religion • Symbols: Rejected Lord Rama, promoted Rajah Bali • Vision: Abolition of caste, equality, human dignity • Women's Rights & Education: Girls' school with Savitribai Phule. Widow remarriage movement, widow shelter (1854) • Political Engagement: Poona Municipal Committee (1876) • Legacy: Impact: Social justice, inclusivity, Western India

Sree Narayana Guru Dharma Paripalana (SNDP) Movement [1903, Kerala]	• Founder: Sree Narayana Guru (1854-1928). Ezhavas (toddy-tappers) faced untouchability, denied education, and temple entry in Kerala. • Catalyst: 1888 symbolic act at Aruvippuram, where Guru installed a Sivalinga from Neyyar River to challenge caste-based practices. • Formation of Movements: 1889: Aruvippuram Kshetra Yogam • 1903: SNDP Yogam registered under the Indian Companies Act with Guru as permanent chairman and Kumaran Asan as general secretary. • Views on Caste: Advocated for religious equality, caste abolition, and human unity. • Famous slogan: “One religion, one caste, one god for mankind” Criticised Congress and Gandhi for not addressing caste discrimination. • Inscribed on the Aruvippuram temple wall: “No dividing walls of caste or race, live in brotherhood.” • Contributions: Promoted social mobility for Ezhavas in education, government jobs, temple entry, and political representation. Played a key role in forming social justice coalitions for backward castes in Kerala. • Impact: Led to structural changes in Kerala’s power dynamics, challenging caste-based discrimination and fostering unity for social justice.
Justice Movement/Party [1916; Madras]	• Founders: Dr. T.M. Nair, P. Tyagaraja Chetti, C.N. Mudaliar Indian Liberation Federation (SILF) formed in 1916 to challenge Brahmin dominance in government service, education, and politics. • Impact: Led to reservations for various communities through government orders. Significance: First non-Brahmin political organisation in South India, advocating for social equality and non-Brahmin representation. • Formation of Justice Party: Represented non-Brahmin interests and social justice. • Periyar’s Leadership (1937-1944): Became President in 1937 and spearheaded anti-Brahminism and social reform. Criticised Hinduism, Laws of Manu, and Puranas as inhumane. Iconic Actions: Removed caste name-boards from hotels, desecrated Hindu idols and cut sacred threads worn by Brahmins, Advocated for the end of Brahmanical Hinduism. • Motto: “Some things cannot be mended, only ended.” • Evolution: 1944: Renamed Dravida Kazhagam (Dravidian Federation) & 1949: Became Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) under C.N. Annadurai, continuing Periyar’s agenda.
Nair Movement [1891; Kerala]	• Key Leaders: C.V. Raman Pillai, K. Rama Krishna Pillai, and M. Padmanabha Pillai. • Context: The movement emerged in response to Brahmin dominance in Kerala. • Key Contributions: C.V. Raman Pillai: Established the Memorial to challenge Brahminical authority. M. Padmanabha Pillai: Founded the Nair Service Society (NSS) to uplift the Nair community and ensure their rights and social mobility. • Significance: The movement aimed at securing social equality for non-Brahmin communities, particularly the Nairs, against Brahminical hegemony.
Self-Respect Movement [1925; Tamil Nadu]	• Founder: E.V. Ramaswami Naicker (Periyar), Tamil Nadu. • Goal: Reject Brahminical customs, challenge caste hierarchy, and promote rationalism • Key Actions: Criticised Brahmin priests as agents of oppression. Advocated for alternative wedding ceremonies and women’s liberation. Mobilised marginalised communities against caste injustice. • Associated Journal: Kudi (1910). • Impact: Reshaped social fabric in Tamil Nadu. Formed Justice Party. Pushed for egalitarianism and social justice.

Movement	Key Contributions and Facts
Nadar Movement [1910; Tamil Nadu]	• Origin: Shanans, an untouchable caste of agricultural labourers in Tamil Nadu. Transformation: By the late 19th century, they became a prosperous mercantile class, adopting the title 'Nadars' to claim Kshatriya status. • Objective: Counter social prejudice and advance welfare for the Nadar community. • Key Organisation: Nadar Mahajan Sangam (established in 1910).
The Depressed Classes (Mahars) Movement [1924; Maharashtra]	• Founder: B.R. Ambedkar. • Objective: Elevate the Mahar community (untouchables) in Maharashtra. • Key demands: Access to public places, temple entry, abolition of Mahar Watan, and separate representation in the legislative council. • 1927: Bahiskrit Bharat Samaj Samta Sangh initiated by the Depressed Classes Institution (Marathi fortnightly). • 1942: Caste Federation formed to advocate for untouchables' rights.
Congress' Harijan Movement [1917 onwards]	Key Leaders: Mahatma Gandhi, Madan Mohan Malviya, Jamnalal Bajaj. Objective: Abolish untouchability and elevate the social status of Dalits. • 1917: Congress passed a resolution advocating for the abolition of untouchability and urged the elimination of customs-imposed disabilities on Dalits. • 1929: Formation of the Anti-Untouchability Sub-Committee within Congress, led by Madan Mohan Malviya and Jamnalal Bajaj. • 1932: All-India Anti-Untouchability League established by Gandhi to further the cause. • Journal: Harijan, published by Mahatma Gandhi
Kaivartas' Movement [1897 onwards; Midnapore, Bengal]	The establishment of the Jati Nirdharan Sabha in 1897 and the Mahishya Samiti in 1901 Marked the initial steps toward the evolution of the Kaivartas' identity, ultimately forming the cohesive identity of Mahishyas.
Vaikom Satyagraha (1924)	• Location: Vaikom, Northern Travancore. • Leader: K.P. Kesava. • Objective: Challenge the denial of untouchables access to temples and public roads. • Support: National attention, with Jathas (processions) from Punjab and Madurai. • Mahatma Gandhi visited Kerala to show solidarity.
Temple Entry Movement (1924-1938)	• Vaikom Satyagraha (1924): Leader: K.P. Kesava • Objective: Demand for the opening of Hindu temples and public roads to untouchables. • Support: Reinforced by Jathas (processions) from Punjab and Madurai. Gandhi visited Kerala in support of the movement. • Guruvayur Satyagraha (1931) Leaders: K. Kelappan and poet Subramaniam Tirumambu (the 'singing sword of Kerala') • Event: 16 volunteers led by Tirumambu marched to Guruvayur to challenge temple entry restrictions for untouchables. • Notable Satyagrahis: P. Krishna Pillai, A.K. Gopalan. • Travancore Proclamation (1936): Maharaja of Travancore issued a proclamation allowing all Hindu castes access to government-controlled temples. • Temple Entry in Madras (1938): Leader: C. Rajagopalachari; Expansion: Madras administration followed suit, expanding the movement's influence across southern India.
Gopal Baba Walangkar	Initiative: Founded Anarya Dosh Parihar Samaj and published 'Vital Vidhwansak' to protest against Brahmanism.

Iyothee Thass (Tamil Nadu)	Advocacy: Promoted Siddha medicine , Buddhist conversion , and founded Dalit Mahajan Sabha .
Aruvippuram Movement (1888)	Key Event: Lower-caste members consecrated a Shiva idol in a temple, challenging caste restrictions. Sri Narayana Guru played a key role.
Vokkaliga Sangha (1905)	It was initiated as an anti-Brahmin movement in Mysore, challenging the prevailing social hierarchy. T.Byanna was the Sangha's first president, and the Maharaja of Mysore, Krishnaraja Wodeyar IV, and Diwan V.P. Madhava Rao was the association's patron and vice-patron, respectively.

SOCIO-CULTURAL REFORM MOVEMENTS

Socio-Cultural Reform Movements Among Hindus

Movement/Organisation [Year & Place]	Description
Swaminarayan Sampraday [Early 19th Century, Gujarat]	• Founder: Swami Sahajanand (Ghanashyama) (1781–1830) • Beliefs and Teachings: Advocated monotheism and a belief in a theistic god, protested against certain practices in Vaishnavism, prescribed a moral code for personal conduct. • Promoted vegetarianism and discouraged the consumption of liquor and drugs. • Inclusivity: Open to all individuals, regardless of caste or creed.
Brahmo Samaj (Earlier Atmiya Sabha) [1828, Calcutta]	• Founder: Raja Rammohan Roy (1772-1833) • Key Developments: ○ Adi Brahmo Samaj: Established by Debendranath Tagore, focused on expanding Rammohan Roy's teachings. ○ Brahmo Samaj of India: Led by Keshub Chandra Sen, with a broader, more organised structure. ○ Sadharan Brahmo Samaj: Formed by those who seceded from Keshub Chandra Sen's group, emphasising a more inclusive approach. • Monotheism: Promoted belief in one God and purified Hinduism. • Core Principles: The movement emphasised reason, upheld the Vedas and Upanishads, rejected idolatry, sacrifices, priesthood, reincarnation, and meditation. It critiqued Sati and promoted human dignity and social reforms. [UPSC 2012] • Associated Journals: Raja Rammohan Roy: <i>Sambad Kaumudi</i>, <i>Mirat-ul-Akbar</i> • Debendranath Tagore: <i>Tattva Bodhini Patrika</i>, Keshub Chandra Sen: <i>Indian Mirror</i> • Sadharan Brahmo Samaj: <i>Tattva Kaumudi</i>, <i>The Indian Messenger</i>, <i>The Sanjibari</i>, <i>Navyabharat</i>, <i>Prabasi</i>
Paramahansa Mandali (1849)	• Founded by: Dadoba Pandurang, Mehtaji Durgaram (Maharashtra) • Focus: Reforming Hindu religion and society, linked to Manav Dharma Sabha • Ideology: Worship one god, love, moral conduct, freedom of thought, rationality. Break caste rules, promote widow remarriage, support women's education • Branches: Poona, Satara, other towns in Maharashtra.

Movement/Organisation [Year & Place]	Description
Young Bengal Movement [1830's Calcutta]	• Founder: Henry Louis Vivian Derozio • Key Figures: Rasik Krishna Mullick, Tarachand Chucker-vati, Krishna Mohan Banerjee • Ideology: Opposed societal vices, advocated for truth, freedom, and reason. Pushed for women's rights, education for women. Established Society for the Acquisition of General Knowledge • Journals: Janavesan, Hesperus, The Calcutta Library Gazette, India Gazette (edited by Derozio) • Demands: Indian representation in higher services, protection for ryots & fair treatment of Indian labour abroad, revision of Company's charter, freedom of the press, trial by jury
Dharma Sabha [1830, Calcutta]	• Founder: Radhakanta Deb (1794-1876) • Ideology: Countered Brahmo Samaj, supported orthodoxy, opposed radical and liberal reforms, including the abolition of sati, promoted Western education & celebrated Indian culture's importance and pride.
Bharat Dharma Mahamandal (1902)	• Leader: Pandit Madan Mohan Malaviya • Objectives: Manage Hindu religious institutions & Promote Hindu education • Formation: Evolved from a coalition of organisations defending orthodox Hinduism (e.g., Sanatana Dharma Sabha, Dharma Maha Parishad, Dharma Mahamandali). Combined in 1902 to form Bharat Dharma Mahamandal with headquarters at Varanasi Opposition: Defended against Arya Samajists, Theosophists, and the Ramakrishna Mission.
Tattvabodhini Sabha [1839, Calcutta]	• Leader: Debendranath Tagore • Objectives: Response to the expansion of Christianity in India, promote Vedantism and indigenous culture, focus on developing Bengali language and texts in various subjects Notable Followers: Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar, Akshay Kumar Dutt, and supporters of Rammohun Roy and Derozio • Key Publications: Tattvabodhini Patrika (promoted the study of India's past with a rational approach)
Students Literary and Scientific Society [1848]	• Objectives: Debate on popular science and social issues Promote the study of literature and science Advocate for the use of vernacular languages in education.
Radhaswami Movement [1861, Agra]	• Founder: Tulsi Ram (Shiv Dayal Saheb); Core beliefs include belief in one supreme being, guru supremacy, and the practice of Satsang (community of pious individuals). It emphasises a simple social life, spiritual fulfilment alongside material life, and acknowledges that all religions are true, rejecting belief in temples or sacred places.
Veda Samaj [1864, Madras]	• Founders: Sridharalu Naidu and Keshab Chandra Sen • Influence: Heavily influenced by Brahmo Samaj, particularly its theistic principles Key beliefs and actions include viewing marriage and funeral rituals as routine, not religious, advocating the elimination of sectarian beliefs, and promoting the gradual eradication of caste distinctions. The movement embraced diverse viewpoints, opposed polygamy and child marriage, and actively supported widow remarriage.

Prarthana Samaj [1867, Bombay]	• Founders: Atmaram Pandurang, with help from Keshab Chandra Sen • Key Mentors: Mahadeo Govind Ranade, RG Bhandarkar • Core beliefs: Monotheism, women's upliftment, and abolition of caste and religious orthodoxy. Promoted devotion to one deity, opposed polytheism, idol worship, and priestly dominance, and updated Hindu practices. Inspired by Buddhism and Christianity, focused on universal spiritual truths. • Social Reform Agenda: Disapproval of caste system, women's education, Widow remarriage & raising the age of marriage for both genders • Important Figures: ○ Mahadeo Govind Ranade joined in 1870, boosting its popularity ○ Dhondo Keshav Karve and Vishnu Shastri contributed to the Widow Remarriage Movement and the Widows' Home Association • Precursor: Paramahansa Sabha, promoting liberal ideas and caste/community breakdown.
Indian Reform Association [1870, Calcutta]	• Founder: Keshub Chandra Sen • Objectives: Build public consensus against child marriages Elevate the social status of women Advocate for the legalisation of marriages following the Brahmo tradition
Arya Samaj [1875, Bombay]	• Founder: Dayanand Saraswati (originally Mula Shankar) • Slogan: "Back to the Vedas" • Key ideas: Rejected rituals, Brahminical dominance, idol worship, and superstitions. Promoted social reform, women's rights, and social equality, challenging untouchability and the caste system. Used Hindi to reach Northern India, established Dayanand Anglo-Vedic (DAV) schools, and contributed to the national movement with values of self-respect and self-reliance.
Theosophical Society [1875, New York, later 1882, Adyar, Madras]	• Founders: Madam H.P. Blavatsky (1831-91), Col. H.S. Olcott (1832-1907) • Key Figures: Annie Besant (President) (UPSC 2013) • Key ideas: Inspired by Upanishads, Vedanta, and ancient philosophies. Aimed at religious revival and social reform, advocating the revival of Hinduism, Zoroastrianism, and Buddhism. Recognized transmigration of the soul, preached universal brotherhood, promoted women's advancement, and fought against untouchability.
Deccan Education Society [1884, Pune]	• Founders: M.G. Ranade, Lokmanya Tilak, V.G. Chibdonkar, G.G. Agarkar • Objective: Advance education as a tool for social change • Key Contributions: Contributed to education and culture in Western India & established • Ferguson College, Pune (1885)
Seva Sadan [1885, Bombay]	• Founder: Behramji M. Malabari • Objective: Advocate against child marriage, promote widow remarriage, and support women exploited and abandoned by society • Key Contributions: Influenced the enactment of the Age of Consent Act, Focused on providing education, medical care, and welfare services to women across all castes, Malabari edited the Indian Spectator, Founded with Diwan Dayaram Gidumal

Movement/Organisation [Year & Place]	Description
Indian National Social Conference [1887, Bombay]	• Founders: M.G. Ranade, Raghunath Rao • Objective: Unite progressive Indian thought on social issues; similar to the Indian National Congress' role in politics. Indian National Congress did not want to include social reforms in its deliberations and decided to form a separate body for such a purpose. [UPSC 2012] • Mission: To fortify social reform forces by gathering representatives from various Indian associations and movements & convened annually, starting in Madras, alongside the Indian National Congress meetings • Key Contributions: Served as the social reform wing of the Indian National Congress, launched the 'Pledge Movement' against child marriage, advocated for inter-caste marriages, opposed polygamy and kulinism (old men marrying young girls)
Deva/Dev Samaj [1887, Lahore]	• Founder: Shiva Narain Agnihotri • Core Beliefs: Closely aligned with the Brahmo Samaj in terms of religious philosophy & advocated for righteous living, emphasising moral behaviour and spiritual discipline • Social Code: Opposed bribery, gambling, alcohol consumption, and non-vegetarian food & promoted non-violence and ethical living • Teachings: Compiled in the book Deva Shastra • Reform Agenda: Strong opposition to child marriage
Madras Hindu Association [1892, Madras]	• Founder: Viresialingam Pantulu • Core Focus: ○ Social Purity Movement ○ Opposition to the Devadasi system ○ Efforts to alleviate the oppression of widows
Ramakrishna Mission [1897, Bengal (centres at Belur and Mayavati were focal points)]	• Founder: Swami Vivekananda (Narendranath Dutta) • Guru: Ramakrishna Paramahansa (Gadadhar Chattopadhyay) • Key Objectives: Rejuvenation of Hinduism through Vedanta and ancient texts. Opposed caste restrictions, oppression, and superstitions. Focused on uplifting women and restructuring the education system. Promoted renunciation and practical spirituality through the Ramakrishna Math and Mission. Advocated service of humanity as devotion to God. • Headquarters: Belur (near Calcutta) • Important Concepts: ○ Oneness of all religions: "As many faiths, so many paths." ○ Service to mankind as service to God: "Service of man is the service of God." • Monastic Focus: Both the Ramakrishna Math and Mission operated as separate but complementary organisations.
The Servants of India Society [1905, Bombay]	• Founder: Gopal Krishna Gokhale, with support from M.G. Ranade • Key Objectives: ○ Focused on famine relief and improving the welfare of tribals, with a strong emphasis on economic upliftment and employment for women. ○ Trained national missionaries to promote the true interests of the Indian people, using constitutional means and preparing selfless workers dedicated to India's cause. • Publications: In 1911, the society began the publication of Hitavada, a newspaper to project its views and efforts. • Leadership After Gokhale's Death: After Gokhale's death in 1915, Srinivasa Shastri took over as president, continuing the society's work.

Poona Seva Sadan [1909, Pune]	• Founders: G.K. Devadhar and Ramabai Ranade (wife of M.G. Ranade) • Key Objectives: Focused on educational advancements for women and the betterment of widows' conditions. & Worked towards empowering women and improving their societal status.
Nishkam Karma Math (Monastery of Disinterested Work) [1910, Pune]	• Founder: Dhondo Keshav Karve • Key Objectives: ○ Established the women's university in Pune, now part of Mumbai University. ○ Emphasised the importance of women's education and self-reliance.
Social Service League [1911, Bombay]	• Founder: Narayan Malhar Joshi • Key Objectives: Improved conditions for the common masses through social welfare activities like schools, libraries, and cooperative societies. Supported legal aid, excursions for slums, medical relief, and boys' clubs. Key role in founding the All India Trade Union Congress in 1920.
Seva Samiti [1914, Allahabad]	• Founder: Hridayanath Kunzru • Key Objectives: Focused on enhancing the status of suffering classes through social service and education.
The Indian Women's Association [1917, Madras]	• Founder: Annie Besant • Key Objectives: Worked towards the upliftment of Indian women by organising annual conferences, such as the All India Women's Conferences. Advocated for women's rights and social reforms across India.

Socio-Cultural Reform Movements Among Muslim

Movement/Organisation [Year & Place]	Description
Wahabi Movement [1820s onwards, Rohilkhand, Kabul, NWFP, Bengal, Central Provinces]	• Leaders: Syed Ahmad of Rai Bareilly (founder), Vilayat Ali, Shah Muhammad Hussain, Farhat Hussain, Inayat Ali (all from Patna). • Regions: Rohilkhand, Kabul, NWFP, Bengal, Central Provinces. • Influences: Inspired by Abdul Wahab (Arabia) and Shah Waliullah (1702–63). • Objectives: The movement sought to revive authentic Islam and Arabian culture as it existed during the Prophet's time. It opposed Western influences on Islam and emphasised the importance of individual conscience in religious matters. • Political Engagement: Initially directed at the Sikhs in Punjab, the movement later shifted focus against the British after the annexation of Punjab (1849). • Role in 1857 Revolt: Played a significant role in spreading anti-British sentiments and mobilising resistance.
Movement/Organisation [Year & Place]	Description
Titu Mir's Movement (1831)	• Leader: Syed Mir Nisar Ali (Titu Mir), a disciple of Syed Ahmad Bareilly and follower of Wahabism. • Focus: Advocated for the implementation of Sharia principles in Bengal and organised Muslim peasants against Hindu landlords and British indigo planters. • Conflict: Titu Mir's movement, although not as militant as portrayed, led to a confrontation with British police in 1831, which resulted in his death.

Faraizi Movement (1818-19)	• Founder: Haji Shariatullah, and later led by his son Dudu Mian. • Initial Focus: The movement sought to spread a reinterpretation of Islam and eradicate un-Islamic practices, especially in East Bengal. • Transformation into Revolutionary Movement (1840): After the British conquest of the region, the movement transformed into a revolutionary force. Dudu Mian organised a paramilitary force to challenge Hindu landlords and Indigo planters who exploited poor peasants. • Organisational System: Dudu Mian developed an organisational structure from the village level to the provincial level, with khalifa (authorised deputies) overseeing each region. • Militant Phase: The movement also led to a rebellion against injustice, with the swift reaction of landlords uprooting the socio-economic foundation of the region.
Taayuuni Movement [Dacca, 1839]	• Leader: Karamat Ali Jaunpuri. • Influences: The movement was founded on the teachings of Shah Waliullah. • Opposition to Faraizi Movement: It stood in opposition to the Faraizi Movement, offering a more traditionalist religious stance without the revolutionary and social reform goals that the Faraizi Movement pursued.
The Mohammedan Literary Society of Calcutta (1863)	• Leader: Abdul Latif. • Aim: To promote modern education and scientific knowledge among Muslims. To eradicate social practices like polygamy among the upper and middle-class Muslims. • Hindu-Muslim Unity: The society also played a pivotal role in fostering Hindu-Muslim unity, aiming to bridge divides and promote social cohesion among different communities in Bengal.
The Deoband School of Islamic Theology [Saharanpur, UP-1866]	• Founded by: Muhammad Qasim Nanaytavi (1832–80) and Rashid Ahmad Gangohi (1828–1905) in Saharanpur, UP. • Key Figures: Maulana Abul Kalam Azad, Mahmud-ul-Hasan, Shibli Numani. • Core Ideals: A revivalist movement focusing on Quranic teachings, rejecting Western education, and advocating a liberal interpretation of Islam. It supported the Indian National Congress and issued a 1888 fatwa against Syed Ahmed Khan's associations. • Key Contributions: Mahmud-ul-Hasan fused Islamic principles with nationalism. Jamiat-ul-Ulema upheld Muslim rights. Shibli Numani supported English, European sciences, and Hindu-Muslim unity.
Aligarh Movement (1875)	• Founder: Syed Ahmed Khan (1817–98). • Key Contributions: Promoted religious reform through rational inquiry in religion, emphasising scientific and rational outlook. Recognized the value of Western education and aimed to socially reform Muslims. Played a pivotal role in founding the Scientific Society in 1864. Associated Journal: Tahziz-al-Akhlaq (Urdu).
Ahmadiyya Movement (1889)	• Founder: Mirza Ghulam Ahmad (1839–1908). • Core Beliefs: Promoted human rights, tolerance, and separation of mosque and state, opposed jihad, favoured Western education, Mirza Ghulam Ahmad claimed to be the Messiah, ending religious wars, Criticised for mystical elements, akin to the Bahai faith. The Ahmadiyya community is the only Islamic sect that holds the belief that the Messiah has already arrived in the form of Mirza Ghulam Ahmad.

Socio-Cultural Reform Movements Among Sikhs & Parsis	
Namdhari or Kuka Movement [1841-71, NWFP, Bhain]	• Founders: Bhai Balak Singh and Baba Ram Singh. • Core Ideals: The movement was a religio-political revival within the Sikh community, emphasising worship of one God through prayer and meditation as outlined in the Rehatnamas. It opposed social issues like the caste system, infanticide, and early marriage, while promoting Anand Marriage ceremonies for egalitarian practices. • Impact: The movement played a significant role in reforming social practices within the Sikh community and challenging traditional practices that were seen as corrupt.
Singh Sabha Movement (1873)	• Founders: Thakur Singh Sandhawalia and Giani Gian Singh. • Core Objectives: The movement aimed to re-establish Sikhism in its original form by publishing religious literature, promoting the use of Punjabi, and reintegrating Sikh apostates. It sought to involve Englishmen in Sikh educational efforts and establish a network of Khalsa schools across Punjab to provide modern education and counter external influences, including Christian missionaries, Brahmo Samaj, Arya Samaj, and Muslim maulvis. Its significance lies in advancing Sikh education and defending Sikhism from external threats.
Akali Movement (1920-25)	• Origins: An offshoot of the Singh Sabha Movement. • Objective: Aimed to liberate Sikh gurudwaras from the control of corrupt Udasi mahants, whose positions had become hereditary. Key Achievements: • 1922: Passed the Sikh Gurdwaras Act (amended in 1925), granting control of gurudwaras to the Sikh masses and empowering the Shiromani Gurudwara Prabandhak Committee (SGPC) as the apex governing body for gurudwara administration. • Characteristics: Non-violent, non-cooperation movement launched in 1921., While it was regional, it was not communal.
Nirankari Movement (1851)	• Founder: Baba Dayal Das. • Core Ideals: The movement opposed idol-worship and veneration of tombs, rejected the militant Khalsa brotherhood, and accepted the living Gurus as spiritual leaders. It also simplified and standardised rituals for birth, health, and marriage. • Impact: The Nirankari Movement emphasised the individual's connection to God and sought to make Sikh religious practices more accessible and relevant.
The Rehnumai Mazdayasan Sabha [1851]	• Founders: Dadabhai Naoroji, Nauroji Furdonji, and S.S. Bengalee. • Core Objectives: The movement aimed to reform orthodox Parsi practices, focusing on modernising social customs, improving women's education, and reforming marriage practices. It advocated for restoring Zoroastrianism's purity and implementing uniform laws on inheritance and marriage within the Parsi community.

